

May 2025 Paper 2: Sample Response 1 (Question 1)

Question 1: Discuss how the writers of two works you have studied depict social tensions.

Writers often use their works to portray social tensions that are pervasive throughout society, addressing the effects of such tensions on individuals and their actions. *Harvest*, a play written by Manjula Padmanabhan takes place in a dystopian future in India, where organ trafficking has become a norm. In *Human Acts*, a polyphonic narrative novel written by Han Kang, various characters suffering from the state-led violence during the 1980 Gwangju uprising is depicted. Both writers, through their respective works, show how oppressive systems act as a medium that create social tensions, where the tensions act as a force that makes individuals grapple with moral ambiguity, agency and humanity. However, Padmanabhan insistently critiques the patriarchal and capitalistic society and how that generates unequal power dynamics, whilst Han focuses on the lasting psychological trauma, and how the oppressive system and the subsequent social tension arising from it creates victims.

Padmanabhan depicts Om as the traditional man of a patriarchal household, where poverty has led him to make the decision of selling his organs to the exploitive InterPlanta Services. The burden of having to be the breadwinner of the family coerces him into making the decision, where he claims that “I was willing to accept anything for the family.” The phrase “willing to accept” is of a passive tone, demonstrating that the decision was one not made of his own volition. Furthermore, by saying “anything,” it shows that to an extent, Om is aware of the potential consequences of his action. This implies that the societal expectation of the man in patriarchal society has created a social tension between Om and

the said expectations that oppresses him. However, Padmanabhan later taints Om's image as a selfless individual that is self-centric. When the InterPlanta Services guards are knocking at the door to harvest his organs, Ma (his mother) tries to open the door unknowingly. Surprisingly, Om lashes out, yelling and threatening to beat his own mother if she was to open that door. It is almost ironic and hypocritical, seeing as Om signs up for the InterPlanta Services for his family, but now he is threatening to hurt the very person he was trying to care for in the first place. This suggests that self-sacrifice maybe a constructed narrative that falls apart under extreme circumstance. Therefore, Padmanabhan shows how the social tension created by the oppressive patriarchy and poverty in a capitalistic society has forced Om to make morally ambiguous decisions, and ultimately succumbing him to the pressure and consequences of his actions.

Unlike Padmanabhan's Om, Han's character, the Prisoner, in chapter 4, is an individual that remains strong despite the oppressive state-led violence. Through his harrowing account of his experience at the prison, one full of extreme physical torture, he shows how social tensions, which arise due to a pro-democratic movement against the military state, has led to dehumanization of individuals. He describes that "sticky pus, blood, saliva, tears, that was all that was left of me." The asyndeton and enumeration of bodily fluids demonstrate the extent of his dehumanization, reducing him to mere parts of his original self. Although the source of social tension is different, both Padmanabhan and Han shows through Om and the Prisoner the effects of oppressive systems on individuals. However, the Prisoner starkly contrasts with Om as he is not afraid of facing the consequences of his actions. In the courtroom, where he and fellow prisoners are on trial due to their protests, they sing the national anthem in solidarity to resist against the State.

This is powerful as not only are they not afraid of the repercussions of their actions, contrasting to Om, but the national anthem also serves as a symbol that criticizes the State: the national anthem, which should represent the State, are the very perpetrators oppressing their own citizens. Thus, Han shows that despite such dehumanization and oppression due to social tensions, it is possible for humanity to emerge and resist against the oppressive system.

Likewise, Padmanabhan's Jaya, is a character that actively resists against the oppressive structure, which is patriarchy and capitalism. Patriarchy has led to social tensions within their family: Om, her husband and Ma, her mother-in-law. When Jaya expresses her concerns regarding Om's decision of selling himself, saying "To be a widow by slow degrees?" this rhetorical question evidently shows her genuine concern. But this is immediately dismissed by Om, who prioritizes his own worries rather than addressing hers. Furthermore, Ma's reference to Jaya as a "slut" reinforces the oppression she forces in her own household. However, despite this, she is the sole individual that attempts to reclaim agency in the oppressive system. When Virgil, who is the "buyer" of Om's organs asks Jaya to bear his children, Jaya claims to have adapted a "I win if you lose mindset" picking up a piece of broken glass and threatening to kill herself. The broken glass is a symbol both physically and metaphorically: on one hand, it represents her physical state and mental state being broken, locked in her house with nowhere to go; on the other hand, it also represents the fragmented state of her household, leaving her as the sole individual having to face the consequences of her family's actions. Therefore, although Jaya resists against the oppressive system, where patriarchal values and poverty worked in tandem to oppress her, she goes as far as to threatening to kill herself to regain her agency to some extent, like

the prisoners in *Human Acts*, resisting against the oppression knowing the potential consequences.

Contrasting to Jaya's solitary resistance against her oppressors, Dong-ho's mother works with other bereaved parents in an act of collective resistance. Han uses a second-person perspective to narrate Dong-ho, the protagonist of the novel, in the first chapter. Later, in chapter 6, Dong-ho's mother's story is narrated in first-person perspective. This is powerful as Han is using synthetic personalization to blur the lines between the novel and the reader, evoking strong emotions. When Dong-ho's mother says "I followed you as soon as I spotted you, Dong-ho" despite knowing that it has been years since Dong-ho died during the Gwangju uprising, the readers feel as if they are Dong-ho, eliciting a strong sense of empathy for Dong-ho's mother. Whilst Padmanabhan's Jaya draws empathy from the sheer solitary state that she is in, Han appeals more towards inherent human emotions of mother-and-son relationship to depict Dong-ho's mother as a victim of the psychological trauma inflicted by the State. In addition, the social tension persists despite it being decades after 1980. Dong-ho's mother and other bereaved parents organize protests against the military regime, describing themselves as "hollow scarecrows," delineating the extent to which they are suffering: they are physically protesting but they are empty on the inside, still mourning the deaths of their children. Therefore, Han shows how although the parents are broken and still full of the psychological trauma, their grief has transformed into determination and collective resistance. Thus, victims of oppressive systems remain affected by the social tension for prolonged periods of time and the trauma that they carry will only perpetuate social tensions. This contrasts with *Harvest* as it ends on a cliffhanger of Jaya threatening to kill herself, but in *Human Acts*, the victims are continuously resisting and

calling for the State to apologize for their actions. So, *Human Acts* show that collective resistance, compared to Jaya's solitary resistance, give strength to the oppressed to fight and ultimately resist against the social tension that has oppressed them, restoring humanity to an extent.

In *Harvest* and *Human Acts*, the perpetrators, or the characters that creates social tension as the ones with the power in the oppressive system, differs in the sense that the audiences/readers can pinpoint Ginni, who later is revealed to be Virgil, in *Harvest*, but cannot in *Human Acts*. Padmanabhan portrays Ginni as the benefactor of the oppressive InterPlanta Services, where the programme is "designed" which shows purposeful intent for the rich to "support poorer sections of the world while gaining fresh bodies." This sentence is ironic as it is an attempt to disguise the oppressive and exploitative nature of InterPlanta Services as an altruistic, philanthropic behavior with the use of the word support. This contradiction that exists within the sentence "supporting" the poor whilst taking their "fresh bodies," an inherent part of the poor, seem paradoxical. Thus, Padmanabhan allows the audience to discern who the antagonist is, and understand the tension's origin. This then allows the audience to pinpoint their anger or stress felt during the play on Ginni. However, Han's purposeful exclusions of a specific antagonist leave the reader without a catharsis. Eunsook, in chapter 5, describes the local police who interrogates her to be an "utterly ordinary man." This image shows how in oppressive systems, even the most ordinary and average person can gain the power and be the perpetrator. The sense of discomfort created by this choice leaves the reader to ponder about how oppressive system scan affect anyone, giving power to some whilst completely dehumanizing others. This idea posed by Han that only the victims carry on the psychological trauma can be seen in Eunsook, where she finds

“shame about eating.” Having experienced a massacre, she now finds the very act of eating as shameful, due to extreme survivor’s guilt – the act for survival has become a betrayal to the dead. This further reinforces the discomfort that the reader faces, similar to that of Jaya who finds that the only way to regain agency is killing herself. Thus, both works show that it is the victim that is disproportionately affected in an oppressive system which creates social tension between the oppressing system and the victims.

Ultimately, both Han and Padmanabhan demonstrate through their works how individual characters navigate the oppressive system that acts as a medium that generates social tension. In *Harvest* by Padmanabhan, the whole range of individuals in the oppressive system and hence the social tension is shown: Om is the exploited victim burdened by patriarchal expectations to support his poverty stricken family; Jaya is a victim of patriarchy within the household that resists despite the power dynamic present between the rich (Virgil) and the poor; and Virgil/Ginni is the perpetrator or the benefactor of the oppressive system that creates social tension. In *Human Acts*, Han shows the various victims suffering from lasting psychological trauma from oppression, and how the victims are the ones having to carry the weight of the suffering. Therefore, both writers invite the reader/audience to consider the effect of oppressive system in the society that they live in, and confront the uncomfortable nature of social tensions by resisting rather than succumbing.

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